

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

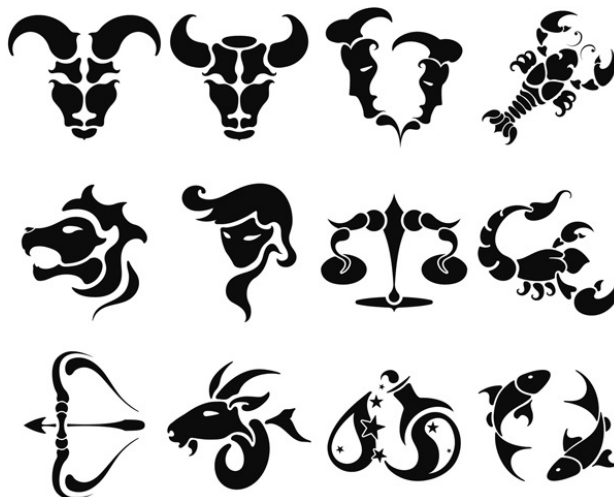
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Let's Start!

Writing Spot: Mercury's retrograde - Can I make you a believer?



Learning Outcome

Exchange information about hypothetical situations in written and spoken interactions according to work and social contexts.

Can Do Statements

- I can write a persuasive paragraph.
- I can write about coincidences and strange events.
- I can write about opinions and beliefs.

Ask your partner:

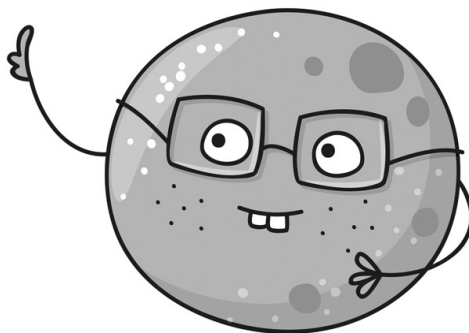
- Do you believe in astrology? What star sign are you?
- Are you a persuasive person? Can you make people change their minds about topics or issue? How?





Let's Explore!

Peter spots an article online about Mercury retrograde. Will Vanessa change her mind?



♀ Mercury

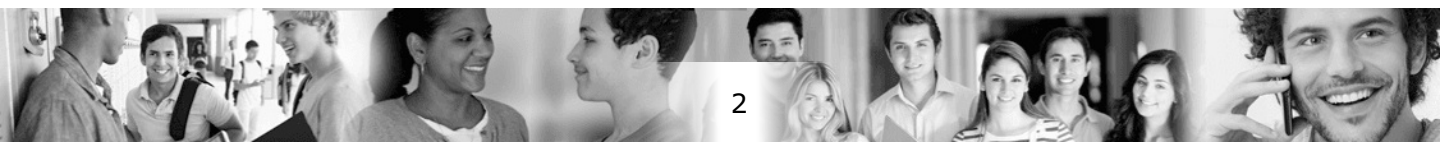
Instructions: Read the text aloud.

Hey Vanessa, check out this online blog. I told you that Mercury retrograde was at the heart of my problems!

Did your mobile phone go on the fritz and your hard drive start acting up within the last couple of weeks? Non-believers may think that their connection is coincidental and astrology to be nonsensical. However, astrologically-minded citizens know the truth. Mercury retrograde, a phenomenon that occurs about three times a year is the obvious culprit. This event, which entails the planet appearing to move backwards in its orbit has a direct correlation with all things related to timing and traffic, transportation and communication. Therefore, as Mercury rules any shift or change in direction this can lead to things on Earth going awry. We all know that earth and the rest of the solar system hold a mysterious past and that there are elements of our existence that cannot be fully explained. On the other hand, skeptics of this phenomenon are unable to provide a plausible alternative explanation.

Due to the unreliability of anything related to technology, gadgets or timing, it is a bad time to start new projects, travel, or do anything new that could fall apart later. Similarly, it is advised that people hold off on making important decisions during this unstable period. With this in mind, some may ask how to survive Mercury retrograde. The answer is - to sit back, relax.

Think twice about your actions and movements. Furthermore, take care of anything that requires re-evaluation and revision. And for the 55-69% of Americans who don't think that astrology is credible, just remember: the planet Mercury will continue to exert its influence, whether you believe it or not.





Let's Practice!

What are these strange events and coincidences?

Instructions: Match the statements from Column A to the ones on Column B. Read the complete sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

COLUMN A

1. Did your mobile phone go on the fritz
2. Due to the unreliability of anything related to technology, it is a bad
3. Mercury retrograde, a phenomenon that
4. This event, which entails the planet appearing to move backward in its orbit, has a direct
5. On the other hand, skeptics of this phenomenon

COLUMN B

- a. time to start new projects, travel, or do anything new that could fall apart later.
- b. occurs about three times a year, is the obvious culprit.
- c. and your hard drive start acting up within the last couple weeks?
- d. correlation with all things related to timing and traffic, transportation and communication.
- e. unable to provide a plausible alternative explanation.



Let's Practice!

The author of the article has a lot of opinions about the role of astrology in our lives.

Instructions: Use the options from the Word Bank to correctly complete the sentences. Use capital letters where necessary. Read the complete sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

Word Bank

I firmly believe / we all know that Earth / it is
advised that people / who don't think that
astrology / I told you that

- 1) _____ Mercury retrograde was at the heart of my problems!
- 2) _____ and the rest of the solar system hold a mysterious past and that there are elements of our existence that cannot be fully explained.
- 3) _____ that Mercury retrograde is the culprit.
- 4) Similarly, _____ hold off on making important decisions during this unstable period.
- 5) And for the 55-69% of Americans _____ is credible, just remember: the planet Mercury will continue to exert its influence, whether you believe it or not.



Extension Activity

Let's put your persuasive skills to the test.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Write a 150-180 word persuasive paragraph about a strange event or coincidence. For example: the belief in aliens, mermaids, robots taking over the world.
- Include both your own and the opposing point of view.
- Use linking words to connect ideas.
- Include the phrases - *I firmly believe ...* and *We all know ...*
- When completed, read the paragraph aloud.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I write a persuasive paragraph about strange events or coincidences.

☐ ☐

I include my own and the opposing point of view in persuasive paragraphs.

☐ ☐

I use linking words to connect ideas.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- plausible** (adjective): possibly true; believable or realistic
e.g. On the other hand, skeptics of this phenomenon are unable to provide a plausible alternative explanation.
- to act up** (verb): to be acting incorrectly
e.g. Did your hard drive start acting up within the last couple weeks?
- culprit** (noun): someone or something that has one something wrong
e.g. Mercury's retrograde, a phenomenon that occurs about three times a year, is the obvious culprit.
- nonsensical** (adjective): very foolish or silly
e.g. Non-believers may think that their connection is coincidental and astrology to be nonsensical.
- correlation** (noun): the relationship between things that happen or change together
e.g. This event, which entails the planet appearing to move backward in its orbit, has a direct correlation with all things related to timing and traffic, transportation and communication.
- awry** (adverb): not working correctly or happening in the expected way
e.g. Therefore, as Mercury rules any shift or change in direction can lead to things on Earth going awry.





Learning Points

Writing Tips: *That*-Clauses: Reporting Verbs to Express Opinions and Beliefs

In writing, you often want to sound more formal than you would in natural conversation. There are some tips to make your writing more formal.

When you use *that*-clauses after some reporting verbs, you can structure it differently to make it sound more formal.

For example:

*I **felt that the results** were satisfactory.*

*I **felt the results to be** satisfactory.*

Here the structure is: object + infinitive

Other verbs you can use in this way are: *acknowledge, assume, believe, consider, declare, expect, find, presume, report, think, understand.*

If you use a *that*-clause after an active form of some verbs, you must include an object between the verb and the *that*-clause.

For example:

*I **notified the bank that** I had changed my phone number.*

Other verbs you use in this way are: *assure, convince, inform, persuade, reassure, remind, tell.*

Examples:

- *I told you that Mercury retrograde was at the heart of my problems!*
- *Non-believers may think that their connection is coincidental and astronomy to be nonsensical.*
- *We all know that earth and the rest of the solar system hold a mysterious past and that there are elements of our existence that cannot be fully explained.*
- *Similarly, it is advised that people hold off on making important decisions during this unstable period.*
- *And for the 55-69% of Americans who don't think that astrology is credible, just remember: the planet Mercury will continue to exert its influence, whether you believe it or not.*
- *I firmly believe that Mercury retrograde is the culprit.*

